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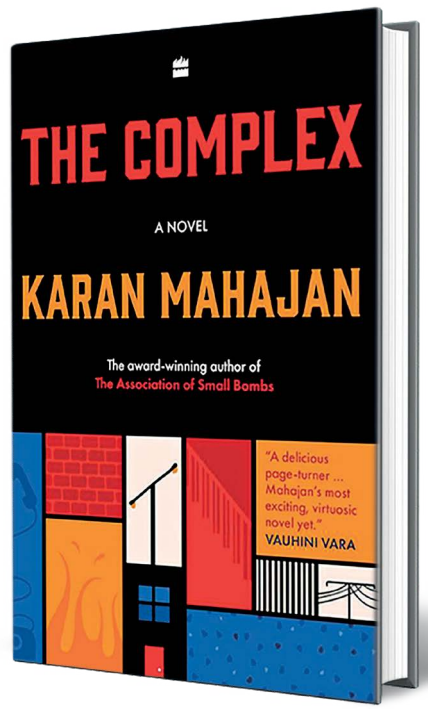
**AN EARLY CHAPTER IN KARAN MAHAJAN'S EXCELLENT NEW NOVEL,** *The Complex*, begins with newlywed New Yorkers Sachin and Gita on a trip back home to Delhi, circa 1980, where Gita's folks live in "déclassé Karol Bagh", whereas Sachin's extended family (the Chopras) live in "the mothership", the family compound in the upmarket "Modern Colony" that lends the novel its name. But the moment that really underlines Mahajan's grasp of Delhi's mercantile ethos happens shortly thereafter, when Sachin's octogenarian great-aunt blesses the couple and gasps the following query in Gita's ear after much effort: "How much does Sachin earn after taxes?"

The 42-year-old Mahajan, an Indian-American writer, has written two novels earlier: *Family Planning* (2008), and *The Association of Small Bombs* (2016), a finalist for the National Book Award for Fiction. ...*Small Bombs* fictionalised the notorious 1996 Lajpat Nagar bomb blast, which claimed 16 lives, and explores the tragedy through point-of-view chapters narrated by victims, perpetrators, cops et al.

Mahajan's latest, *The Complex*, unfolds like a grand old Russian family drama, as Sachin and Gita's lives become increasingly entangled with that of Lakshman, Sachin's villainous uncle and the youngest son of his grandfather S.P. Chopra, freedom fighter and one of the framers of India's constitution, who had also served as RBI governor. Lakshman's fragile sense of masculinity, his quick temper and his deeply regressive views about women are made clear early in the novel. His story arc in the novel takes him from local-level organising to mainstream electoral politics via a (fictional) right-wing Hindu nationalist party. In parallel, his acts of violence and cruelty against the women in his family (including and especially Gita) keep escalating, thereby cementing the Chopra family as a kind of synecdoche for the Indian nation-state.

Talking about the novel's origins and his decision to set it within a family compound, Mahajan says, "I initially wanted to set the novel at the colony level and even call it 'COLONY', especially because of that word's implications. I had all this research into the way Delhi's colonies had been set up. For example, the Ford Foundation, which was responsible for some of the urban planning, had this idea that colonies would give Indian people an identity other than caste or religion—little did they know that each of their colonies would soon have a mandir, a masjid and so on. Eventually, of course, I decided to make the setting a family compound instead of an RWA."

Mahajan is especially skilful while showing us the similarities and differences between the men of the Chopra clan. Seen from the outside, Gita's husband Sachin is a much more evolved man than the boorish Lakshman. But there are limits to Sachin's progressiveness—he gets irritated by assertive career-driven women in one scene. In another, he is quick to use racialised language against a Hispanic man he suspects Gita is sleeping with. Another major parallel between Lakshman and Sachin is the way they both use nation-building as a vessel into which fears, doubts and insecurities are poured. Lakshman's nation-building, of course, happens via his Hindutva politics. And when there's trouble brewing in Sachin and Gita's marriage in New York, Sachin is quick to engineer a return home to India.




**THE COMPLEX**
*By Karan Mahajan*
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**₹799; 428 pages**

Talking about the Chopra men, Mahajan says, "When you think of any of these great Independence-era figures like Jawaharlal Nehru or Sardar Patel, one reason they are relatively unsullied is that they were helping liberate us from the British. At that point in time, their reputations were unaffected by the day-to-day business of actually running the country. So when you have a character like S.P. Chopra, it was always going to be an uphill task for his heirs to live up to that level of greatness."

*The Complex* also shows us the gendered nature of migration, not just through Gita but also through characters like her Indian-American friend Simranpreet, who insists on being called 'Cindy'. Cindy has adopted the American life with